cusing it of uprooting several historical *mutts* that were integral to the temple, and blaming the BJD for disrespecting Hindu sentiment.

It doesn't stop Pandian from using the Jagannath temple revamp to good effect. Besides playing videos of the makeover just before every election meeting, Pandian also starts every speech with a "*Jai Jagannath*", always eliciting an enthusiastic response from the crowds. Indeed, Pandian's poll meetings are carefully-choreographed affairs, with him touring the bulk of the assembly seats and Naveen handling most of the Lok Sabha election rallies. Pandian is careful to project Naveen's work in all the meetings, describing himself as "a loyal soldier of the CM". On a helicopter ride to an election rally in Chilika, Pandian had his office compile the details of all that the government has done for the constituency, including the money spent, the key issues and steps taken to sort them out, besides an updated poll on how the party is faring in that constituency. Before he arrives at a venue, songs in praise of Naveen are played and films showing his welfare schemes and development work screened. Pandian's speeches are a bit longer than Naveen's, but again highlight the major schemes of his government and the Nabin Odisha (new Odisha) mission the CM plans for his sixth term. It will include free electricity for 90 per cent of domestic households, a separate Rs 1 lakh crore budget for the youth for the next 10 years, a gender budget to enable women to be successful entrepreneurs and free loans of up to Rs 5 lakh for farmers as also free electricity. There is also a raft of schemes to improve the lot of tribals, who constitute 22 per cent of the state's population.

Not only has Pandian's star status set off murmurs within his own party, the 50-year-old has also become the favourite punching bag of the BJP. A fitness freak and a long-distance runner, Pandian has been Naveen's close aide for over a decade now. He shot into the limelight when he thwarted a coup attempt by Pyarimohan Mohapatra, ironically another IAS officer-turned-politician and close to Naveen's father Biju Patnaik. After Naveen was elected CM in 2000, Mohapatra became his political advisor and was made a Rajya Sabha member in 2004. But in May 2012, when Naveen was in London, he fomented a revolt against him in the BJD. Pandian, who had caught Naveen's eye for his efficiency during his stint as collector in Ganjam, the home district of his constituency, blew the whistle, which led to Naveen cutting his trip short and sacking Mohapatra. Pandian's wife Sujata Karthikeyan, who is an IAS officer herself and is from Odisha, was the driving force behind Mission Shakti before the Election Commission relieved her of the charge before campaigning began.



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

TO WIN OVER THE YOUTH, NAVEEN HAS FOCUSED ON MODERNISING SCHOOLS AND PROVIDING WORLD-CLASS SPORTS FACILITIES FOR THEM

BJD-BJP PART WAYS

Pandian's move centre stage has given the BJP the perfect handle to project Naveen as a weak and effete CM whose time is up. This, when the saffron was all set to tie up with the BJD for a seat-sharing arrangement just before the 2024 election schedule was announced. While the BJD was willing to concede more Lok Sabha seats to the BJP, talks broke down when the latter demanded a sizeable number of seats for the legislative assembly as well. Pradhan apparently was against any tie-up with the